

SESSION ZERO: FOUNDATIONS

The Qilvayas Symphony

A table-setting primer for the Dungeon Master — 4 to 6 players, characters starting at 3rd level

PURPOSE OF THIS SESSION

Session Zero is played out of character. Its job is to produce five things before dice ever hit the table: a party with all three academy houses represented, a shared history that explains why these specific people trust each other, an admission story for each character that hands the DM a personal thread to pull later, a named mercenary company the players are invested in founding, and a common understanding of tone. Everything below serves one of those five outputs.

The party begins as final-year students at the Imperial Academy of the Lupine Throne, already a cohesive unit, currently away from the capital completing their final field exercise. Session Zero establishes how they became that unit; Session One opens with the exercise already underway.

CHARACTER CREATION RULES

Level: 3rd. This puts subclasses online for every class and lets the party absorb the Session One climax without a tuned kid-gloves encounter.

Ability Scores: 27-point buy or standard array (15, 14, 13, 12, 10, 8), DM's preference. Avoid rolled stats for this campaign — the political and social pillars punish a party with a dump-stat face.

Hit Points: Maximum at 1st level, average (rounded up) at 2nd and 3rd.

Races and Sources: DM's discretion. Note that Drow carry imperial resonance in this setting — the Emperor himself is Drow — so a Drow PC is a statement, not just a stat line. Worth a conversation if anyone picks one.

Equipment: Standard class and background starting equipment, plus the Academy Field Kit: an academy uniform and house insignia, a student signet (functions as identification in imperial-loyal territory), a writing kit, and a 25 gp field stipend remaining from the exercise advance.

Advancement: Milestone leveling recommended. Suggested pace: 4th level after the meeting with the Seeress concludes (early Session Three); 5th at the close of the Proving (end of Session Four); 6th at the Second Seal (end of Session Six). XP totals are listed in the session documents for tables that prefer XP.

HOUSE SELECTION AND PARTY BALANCE

Each character selects a primary house per the class placement guide in the campaign sourcebook (summarized below). Left entirely alone, most parties skew heavily toward

House of the Craft, because it is deliberately the catch-all for casters and specialists. That skew will make Session One harder than it needs to be. Before backgrounds get locked, ask the table directly: who wants to be the one who fights, who wants to be the one who talks, who wants to be the one who notices things. Aim for at least one Sword-primary and one Seal-primary (or Seal-flavored) character in any group of four or more.

House of the Sword: Barbarian, Fighter, Monk. Paladins whose concept is a warrior shaped by faith.

House of the Seal: Paladins who see themselves as religious champions first; Clerics with a doctrinal or pastoral focus.

House of the Craft: Artificer, Bard, Cleric, Druid, Ranger, Rogue, Sorcerer, Warlock, Wizard.

Every character should also name one cross-training discipline from a house other than their primary — a single sentence is enough ("took two years of siege engineering," "studied contract law," "trained with the legion quartermasters"). This costs nothing mechanically. It exists so the DM can hand out moments of expertise later, and because cross-training is the academy's entire institutional philosophy.

ADMISSION STORIES

The capital academy admits through a lottery that is less fair than it appears. Each player chooses (or rolls d6) an admission story. Each one hands the DM a thread: a family, a patron, a debt, a home region, a resentment. Record these — they are the cheapest personal hooks the campaign will ever get. Anchor each story to a real place: the sourcebook's Atlas of the Fractured Empire names the regions (the loyalist Ostmark and Suthmark, the warlord Brekelands, the merchant delta of Velmareth, the See of Orlath, and the rest), and an admission story tied to a named territory becomes a plot hook the moment that territory enters play. One flag: a Drow character is now an even larger statement than before — the Drow are the Founder's Blood, the dynasty's own nearly-vanished people, and a Drow stranger will be read as dynastic kin, claimant, or something without a name (see the sourcebook, Peoples of the Empire, before allowing one). A character from Tarnovar is a statement of similar order, and worth a private conversation — the DM should read the Atlas entry's DM-only note before allowing it, and no Tarnovari character should begin play knowing anything their culture itself does not know.

1 — Lottery Winner: A genuine winner. Talented, probably common-born, owes nobody anything — and is quietly resented by classmates who know how rare that is. Thread: the home community that celebrated them, and what it expects back.

2 — The Donation: A wealthy family made a generous gift to the academy, and admission followed. The character

knows it. Thread: the family's expectations, and whether the character intends to meet them.

3 — The Hostage: A son or daughter of a border lord or ambitious noble, kept close to the capital to ensure a parent's good behavior. In law this is hostage-diplomacy, a formal category and emphatically not bondage: the character retains full legal personhood and is owed treatment as an honored, if constrained, guest (see the sourcebook, Law, Oath, and Bound Labor). Whether their actual experience has matched that standard is the character's to decide. Thread: the parent's politics, and what happens back home if relations with the throne sour.

4 — The Protégé: A regional lord or power spotted talent and sponsored it, expecting a return on the investment. Thread: the patron, and the first favor they will eventually call in.

5 — The True Believer: Sought admission out of genuine conviction — in the empire, the Lupine Matron, or the Emperor's restoration. Thread: what happens to faith when the institution disappoints it.

6 — The Quiet Irregularity: The paperwork says lottery. It wasn't — a forged record, a bribed clerk, a swapped name. The character may not even know who arranged it, or why. Thread: whoever did it, and what they wanted. (DM note: this one is a gift — it can be wired into any faction later.)

FORGING THE PARTY

The academy houses students in mixed residential halls by year and cohort, so the party plausibly shared a dormitory for four years. Do not just assert the bond — co-author it. Put these questions to the table and let players answer in any order, building on each other:

What incident in your first or second year turned you from hallmates into allies? (A hazing gone wrong, an unfair accusation one of you took the blame for, a house competition you conspired to win.)

Which earlier field exercise did you survive together, and what went wrong on it? (This is the party's shared war story. It should have gone badly enough to matter.)

Each player, name one thing you trust absolutely about the character to your left, and one habit of theirs that drives you mad.

Who first said, out loud, "we should do this for ourselves after graduation" — and who took the most convincing?

THE COMPANY

Have the players name their future mercenary company during Session Zero, before the campaign begins. This is deliberate. The company is the party's shared dream — the plan the vision is about to interrupt — and it lands much harder if it is their invention rather than a line of backstory. Let them argue about the name. Let them design a charter, a motto, a rule ("we never work for slavers," "equal shares, always"). Every rule they write is a promise — and in this campaign, promises are load-bearing. Write them all down.

TONE CHECK

Run a short, explicit conversation about tone. This campaign is built on moral complexity — an idealistic emperor whose methods may darken, factions with legitimate grievances on every side, and a central threat fed

by betrayal. Confirm the table wants that, and establish lines and veils as normal. Two specific checks worth making: first, is the table comfortable with the campaign posing questions that have no clean answer (whether the empire should be restored at all is genuinely contestable); second, how much darkness is welcome around themes of institutional corruption, religious politics, and violence against civilians. Calibrate accordingly — the material flexes either direction.

WHAT THE PLAYERS SHOULD NOT KNOW

DM eyes only. The players should leave Session Zero knowing the setting material marked as public in the sourcebook: the empire's decline, the academy, the Emperor's restoration project, the Lupine Matron and the general shape of the faith, and the existence of theological dispute about the founder. They should know nothing of the Founding Myth's buried account — Threnvos, the broken oath, the Oathbreaker — nothing of the shadow's nature or its feeding mechanism, nothing of Vaelindra (she enters play in Session Two), and nothing about the truth of Empress Nyreeza's disappearance beyond the public mystery. Above all, they must never hear the word Proving: the academy's staged final examination (Sessions Three and Four) only works if no player has any reason to suspect the institution stages anything, ever. If a player builds a paladin or cleric, resist the urge to foreshadow early. Their moment comes later, and it will be worth the wait.

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"We are the Kin of Great Timberwolf"